attacking soldiers has been framed that way. They behave as if they are shooting at digital bogeymen.

We decided to unveil the leaked video at a press conference in Washington on 5 April 2010. That gave us ten more days to get Kristinn and Ingi to Baghdad, to find the families of the victims. Sometimes, in the late hours, I would go outside the house for a breath in the cold night air, taking in that fresh scent of sulphur that fills the air in Iceland, and I would wonder how on earth we were going to pull it together in time. There were many campaigns and many miles, and now, many years, between me and the teenage boy who used to stay up all night tramping through the computer systems of corporations across the globe. With the bite of the air, and the Washington deadline snapping at our heels, it seemed at the same time as if everything had changed and nothing had. At the last minute, Kristinn managed to pull some favour with the Icelandic Ministry of Foreign Affairs and suddenly they were off to Baghdad. A fixer they met through the local Reuters office got them into Al Amin, the area of the city run by the Mahdi Army where the atrocity took place. The very day before I set off for Washington the news came back from Iraq: Ingi and Kristinn had found the children and also the widower of a woman killed when the helicopter unleashed Hellfire missiles into a block of flats directly after the attack on the men in the street.

By the skin of our teeth, we got to America and down to the Washington Press Club. It was mid-morning and the room was packed. We played the video and it had an immediate impact. A number of people in the audience were crying. You could see this was no ordinary revelation; the people in there were hardened, but they couldn’t fail to respond to these hidden images of war’s sanctioned brutalism. However, when it came to questions, well, as usual they were disappointing. A lot of people who cover world affairs from Washington are basically stupid. They often know absolutely nothing about the subjects or the cultures they are reporting on; there’s this kind of too-cool-for-school mentality among the older ones, imagining there’s nothing they haven’t seen before. These people are pretty desperate and they should be ashamed, most probably, of how much complacency and ignorance they have brought into the world. But that’s that. Everyone’s so frightened of the national press corps in America that pulling the rug from underneath their sorry, negligent arses hardly seems an option. They don’t listen and they would be insulted to have to question their own categories.